

The movie opened in 1946 and was a box-office flop. Postwar America was in the mood for morally ambiguous noir, not feel-good small-town sentimentality.

Bedford Falls (now Pottersville) looks very different. "Each man's life touches so many other lives," says Clarence, and this ultimately is the movie's message.

Perceived as an optimistic movie, perhaps it can also be seen as one that shows the world as a glass half empty rather than half full. For Capra, George is one man who makes all the difference in people's lives; he is not the Everyman that we all are or could be. In that sense,

the movie may be a warning that we are not all in it together: some people, happily for those around them, are simply less selfish than others.

Accidental classic

The movie's later popularity involves another twist. Due to a legal error, it fell out of copyright in 1974, enabling it to be shown on TV with no repeat fees. The oversight has since been corrected by the studio, something George might have had a few things to say about. ■

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It is a story of being trapped, of compromising, of watching others move ahead and away, of becoming so filled with rage that you verbally abuse your children, their teacher and your oppressively perfect wife.

Wendell Jamieson

The New York Times, 2008

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Frank Capra Director

At the height of his career, Frank Capra was the biggest director in Hollywood, leading the escapist assault on the Depression years with a slew of Oscar-winning comedies. Having moved to Los Angeles from Sicily at the age of five in 1903, he studied chemical engineering but struggled to find work. After bluffing his way into a movie studio in San Francisco, he landed work in Hollywood, directing silent one-reelers with comedy mogul Hal Roach. Effortlessly moving into the sound age thanks to his engineering skills, Capra came into his own in the 1930s. After making propaganda movies in World War II, he saw his star begin to wane; his best-known movie, *It's A Wonderful Life*, was not a commercial hit. Increasingly disillusioned with Hollywood, he started making educational movies on science in the 1950s. He died in 1991.

Key movies

1934 *It Happened One Night*

1938 *You Can't Take It With You*

1939 *Mr. Smith Goes to Washington*

1946 *It's a Wonderful Life*